The ‘Difficulty’ of Being Indian

I distinctly remember that on the eve of the Yatra, I was full of excitement and very aware that something historic and audacious was being attempted. My only worry was whether the people were going to come out in support of the Yatra. However, all that changed within a few days. My fears were unfounded; the people were coming out in huge numbers to support us. However, now the lofty fear had been replaced by a banal but deep discomfort with the food being served in Kerala. It was not as if the quality of the food was bad, but the dishes and their preparation did not suit my palate. One of the most interesting things about Kerala was the ubiquitous fruit and juice shops that dotted our route. I used to have a lot of fruits and juices while walking, but they could not compensate for the food being served.

After walking around 25 kilometres in the heat, I used to be famished and mechanically ate whatever vegetarian food was on offer. To be honest, it did not taste all that good. There was no dal-roti, which could comfort me psychologically. Therefore, I ate little during the Kerala leg, or, in fact, throughout the southern leg of the Yatra and as a result lost a few kilos as well. I still remember the first time I got dal-roti-sabzi in Maharashtra—it was a mixture of relief and happiness. It was the first time I felt full on the Yatra. As a resident of Madhya Pradesh, I always lacked a sense of cultural belonging, because my state is an ensemble of different cultures. However, this discomfort made me aware of my deep entrenchment within north Indian culture. It also made me think about how my fellow yatris from the south would now feel for the remainder of the route when we moved towards the north.

It made me realize that it is not easy to be an Indian because one needs to cultivate a high degree of empathy and tolerance for difference to become truly Indian. To be able to respect differences, perhaps more than any other nation in the world, is a necessary condition for being an Indian citizen. The degree of diversity that an Indian is expected to respect is unprecedented when compared to any other nation. And while at the level